

BUSINESS EMAIL COMPROMISE

The Boss Scam. ■

Spot a fake CEO or manager request in ten seconds.

It arrives looking ordinary. A message from your boss, an urgent tone, a request that sounds reasonable. That ordinariness is the weapon. Boss impersonation and Business Email Compromise drain billions from companies every year, and they work on careful people. Here is what to look for.

FIVE SIGNALS IT ISN'T REALLY YOUR BOSS

01

Urgency wearing a mask of secrecy

“Do this now, and keep it between us.” Genuine requests almost never need silence to survive.

02

The wrong channel entirely

A personal number, a lookalike email domain, or an app you'd never normally use for work approvals.

03

It ends in money or credentials

Wire transfers, gift cards, one-time passwords, logins. A real boss doesn't collect these over chat.

04

Suddenly unreachable the usual way

“In a meeting, can't take a call” is the oldest line in the playbook. Convenient, and deliberate.

05

Pressure to skip the process

Bypassing an approval step or a second sign-off isn't a side effect. It's the whole objective.

WHEN A REQUEST SMELLS WRONG

The 3-step protocol.

Run this the moment any payment, credential, or urgent ask lands from “your boss.” It takes under a minute, and it breaks the scam every time.

1

Pause

Do nothing yet. The urgency is the manipulation, not a reason to move faster. Give yourself the ten seconds the scam is built to steal.

2

Verify on a second channel

Reach your boss a way you already trust. Call the number saved in your phone. Never the number, link, or reply-to in the suspicious message itself.

3

Confirm in writing

For anything involving money or access, get written confirmation through your normal approval process before a single step is taken.

- *No real boss will ever penalise you for pausing to check a payment.*

NOT SURE ABOUT A MESSAGE RIGHT NOW?

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